PSY 101 – Stress and Coping

Module 4 · Prepared for first-year students · Reading time: 20 minutes

1. What stress is

Stress is the response of the body and mind to demands that a person sees as challenging or threatening. Not all stress is harmful: **eustress** is positive stress that motivates, such as the push before a performance, while **distress** is negative stress that feels overwhelming and lowers performance over time.

In the transactional model of Lazarus and Folkman (1984), stress depends on appraisal. In *primary appraisal* a person asks whether a situation is irrelevant, positive, or stressful. In *secondary appraisal* the person asks whether they have the resources to cope with it. The same exam can be a challenge for one student and a threat for another.

2. The stress response

When a threat is noticed, the sympathetic nervous system triggers the “fight-or-flight” response. The adrenal medulla releases adrenaline (epinephrine), which raises heart rate, blood pressure and breathing rate within seconds.

A slower pathway is the HPA axis. The hypothalamus releases CRH, which signals the pituitary gland to release ACTH, which in turn signals the adrenal cortex to release **cortisol**. Cortisol raises blood sugar for energy, but when it stays high for weeks it weakens the immune system and disturbs sleep.

3. General Adaptation Syndrome

Hans Selye described three stages of the body's reaction to long-lasting stress:

Stage	What happens	Example
Alarm	The body notices the stressor and the fight-or-flight response starts.	Hearing about a surprise quiz.
Resistance	The body stays on alert and uses energy to adapt to the stressor.	Studying late every night during exam week.
Exhaustion	Resources run out; illness, fatigue and burnout become likely.	Getting sick right after finals.

4. Ways of coping

Problem-focused coping changes the situation itself: making a study schedule, asking a teacher for help, or splitting a big project into smaller tasks. It works best when the stressor can be controlled.

Emotion-focused coping changes how a person feels about the situation: deep breathing, exercise, talking with friends, or reframing the problem. It works best when the stressor cannot be changed, such as waiting for exam results.

Filipino culture adds its own ways of coping. *Bahala na* can express trust and courage when facing uncertainty, and *pakikisama* (getting along with others) and the idea of *kapwa* (shared identity) make it natural to seek support from barkada and family. For example, a student commuting from Parañaque or Las Piñas who worries about a long trip to a morning exam can plan the route the night before (problem-focused) and listen to music on the way (emotion-focused).

5. Measuring stress

The Perceived Stress Scale (PSS-10) by Cohen, Kamarck and Mermelstein (1983) asks ten questions about the past month. Scores range from 0 to 40: 0–13 is low stress, 14–26 is moderate, and 27–40 is high perceived stress.

Key reminders

- Sleep of seven to nine hours helps the body recover from the stress response.
- Regular physical activity lowers cortisol and improves mood.
- Social support is one of the strongest protections against distress.
- Seek help from the guidance office when stress affects daily life for more than two weeks.